

Sophora (Japanese Pagoda Tree)

Styphnolobium japonicum



Origin

Native to China and Korea, historically planted near temples and palaces; sometimes reclassified in scientific literature under the name *Styphnolobium japonicum*.

Look for

It's one of the few street trees that flowers in August, when almost nothing else nearby is blooming -- a useful clue for identifying it from a distance.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Twig: young twigs often stay green even in winter.
- Leaf: compound leaf with smooth-edged leaflets.
- Flower: creamy-white clusters bloom in late summer (August), unusually late for a street tree.
- Commonly confused with: honeylocust (sophora's leaflets have smooth edges and its twigs stay green, unlike honeylocust's).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Compound leaves with smooth-edged leaflets emerge on green young twigs.
Summer	Creamy-white flower clusters bloom in late summer, unusually late for a street tree.
Fall	Leaves turn pale yellow.
Winter	Young twigs often stay noticeably green even in winter.

DID YOU KNOW

- Despite its common name 'Japanese pagoda tree,' it's native to China, not Japan -- it was simply introduced to Europe through Japanese trade ports.
- Its late-summer flowers are an important nectar source for bees when many spring bloomers have already finished.